

Intellectual Paralysis: *A Critique on Aristotle's Life of Virtue*

In order to understand Aristotle's account of action, it is essential to understand why humans – and the first principles that guide rational action – are inherently different from other animals. His account of action is heavily reliant on this distinction, which then guides his discussions of desire, imagination, flourishing, and the pursuit of knowledge. In the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle delineates different ways of living within humanity, but these distinctions are not central to this critique (*NE* I.5.1095b16-19). What is more pertinent is the nutritive capacity present in all animals (*DA* II.2.413a27-34). Aristotle includes this capacity in humans and suggests that those who live solely for pleasure fail to fulfill their inherent purpose for flourishing by leaving rational activity behind (*NE* I.5.1095b20). Accordingly, the inverse is true: those who act rightly orient their lives toward contemplation, thereby acting in harmony with the inbuilt capacity for virtue. Aristotle's construction, despite its comprehensiveness, structurally paralyzes actors from ever making a decision.

Under his construction of action, reason is what enables humans to act rightly when properly oriented toward the good; appetite often appeals to what is most apparent to an individual, which commonly complicates action by presenting more compelling and simple desires to the appetitive part of the soul. While his distinction is compelling insofar as it explains why humans are able to surpass simple evolutionary preferences in order to flourish, it problematically assumes that this version of flourishing is any different from a plant's capacity to lean toward the sun.

While the account of action constructed in *De Motu Animalium*, *De Anima*, and the *Nicomachean Ethics* rightly demanded entire treatises to explain, this critique will condense five principles and present a provisional representation of the larger argument. Aristotle's teleological

account, description of the universal desire for knowledge in humans, distinction between potentiality and actuality, the practical syllogism, and imagination or *phantasia* will define this target.

A teleological account is directly antithetical to existentialist interpretations of purpose; it assumes that being is imbued with purpose, whereas the existentialists argue that being comes before purpose. The opening of the *Nicomachean Ethics* demonstrates his teleological argument: every art, inquiry, action, and pursuit aims at some good; the good, then, is what all these phenomena aim toward (*NE* I.1.1094a1-3). Accordingly, there is some natural end in humanity that commonly guides these actions. The teleological account establishes that humans have an innate orientation toward the good, which Aristotle identifies with the capacity for reason (*NE* I.7.1097b22-1098a18). This capacity is necessary for a virtuous life, but it is not sufficient: one must also habitually incorporate reason into action to truly flourish (*NE* II.1.1103a20-28 & VI.13.1144b4-21).

The desire for knowledge is another necessary component of his framework of action. He introduces this desire by claiming that all men desire knowledge, which is evidenced by the natural liking of the perceptual capacities (*Metaphysics* I.1.980a21-22). This reflects a nearly universal experience: those with perception like to exercise their senses. As those with eyes experience the pleasures of their ability to see, it is reasonable to assume that humans are predisposed to perceive. Furthermore, as all actions aim at some good, the human capacity for perception enhances the available information for deliberation and right action (*NE* VI.9.1141b35-36).

While desire and inbuilt purpose are important in understanding his account of action, it is the compartmentalization of potentiality and actuality that most thoroughly grounds action in

lived experience. If one is to perceive and act rightly in any given circumstance, and it is assumed that given circumstances have inbuilt variety, there are also a variety of different actions a person may take in a lifetime. Accordingly, there are a variety of different capacities that are not necessarily activated in all actions. Aristotle divides first and second potentiality while keeping actuality entirely separate. First potentiality, in his argument, is the capacity to acquire capacity (*DA* II.5.416a24-26). In the context of a potential pianist, for example, the ability to learn piano falls under the first potentiality. The second potentiality is the actual refinement of the given skill or ability (*DA* II.5.416a26-28). Training to be fluent in music theory or musicianship may fit this requirement, but no immediate playing of the piano is included in second potentiality. Actually playing the piano, then, is the actualization of this training (*DA* II.5.416a28-30). As a pianist need not play piano at all times to retain their title, this construction effectively demonstrates the states of action that a given capacity fluctuates within during a lifetime.

After accounting for inbuilt purpose, desire, and the nature of capacities, Aristotle uses the practical syllogism as the basic logic which determines human action. As described in *De Motu Animalium*, “‘I should drink’, says appetite. ‘And this is drinkable’, says perception or appearance. At once he drinks” (*DMA* 7.701a31-32). The simple logic – I need A, A is present, so I take A – is strikingly clear and a universally intelligible thought process. Especially in the context of Aristotle’s broader framework, the practical syllogism stands out as an example of the advantages of symbolic reason. If one can place symbols over items of desire, the process by which desire becomes action is distilled into simple equations of preference.

To illustrate phantasia, it is necessary to describe all three aspects of Aristotle’s account in *De Anima*: basic movement, imagination, and wish. These aspects are manifestations of the

nutritive, perceptual, and rational capacities of humanity. Aristotle identifies basic movement in the nutritive element of the soul: “For the most natural of all functions for a living thing, if it is complete and not defective and does not come to be by chance, is to produce another thing of the same sort as itself (an animal, if it is an animal, and a plant, if it is a plant), in order to share as far as it can in the everlasting and divine. For this is the end they all strive for” (*DA* II.4.415a27-415b1). Whereas basic movement originates in the nutritive element of the soul, imagination – or *phantasia* – originates in the perceptual component of the soul. Imagination, then, mediates between bodily appetite and reason. Beyond these more basic aspects, the highest element in Aristotle’s account is the rational part of the soul. The rational part of the soul is the seat of practical and theoretical reason (*DA* III.4.429a14-18), and rests on his earlier claim that the capacity for virtue is inherent to rational animals – or, humans (*NE* I.13.1102a19-24).

Combined, the previously described elements form a rather complete framework for human action and preference. What remains unclear, however, is the distinction between perceptual and deliberative animals. Aristotle describes the difference here:

“Now, the other animals as well <as human beings> also have perceptual appearance, as we have said, but <only> reasoning animals have deliberative appearance. For when we come to the question whether one is to do this or that, we come to a task for reasoning. And <in this case> one must measure by one <standard>, since one pursues the greater <good>. And so one is able to make one object of appearance out of many. And this is why <nonrational animals> do not seem to have belief; it is because they lack the <appearance> resulting from reasoning” (*DA* III.11.434a5-12).

This illustration clearly divides perceptual and deliberative animals by the uniquely rational capacity to rank many actions and decide the most advantageous among them. Among the variables within Aristotle's account of action, a problem emerges with his distinction: the implied existence of a 'correct' action undermines the significance of deliberation. Despite the comprehensiveness and internal coherence of his argument, the implication that actions can be ranked is difficult to reconcile with all variables within the outlined account.

Aristotle uses the teleological account to set up a natural end to human action. While it provides a useful framework, the existence of a natural end undermines the value of deliberation itself. Aristotle defines virtuous action as the road to happiness. Given that there is only one correct way for every individual to lead a virtuous life (*NE* II.6.1106b26-29), one is restrained by the path to flourishing. Furthermore, the claim that humans are oriented towards this goal – while appropriately tentative in accounting for the vicious – implies a passivity in virtuous people. Considering Aristotle's stated importance of deliberation – action guided by intent – passive virtue is left unaddressed despite the apparent contradiction in the framework itself.

While virtuous passivity is an issue on its own, Aristotle accounts for other potential benefits of deliberation in his description of the human desire for knowledge. The human capacity for reason, together with an innate desire for knowledge, presents an inbuilt mechanism for a virtuous life. This mechanism, however, is once again disrupted by a "right" action. One's circumstances – and their unique path to happiness – depend on their ability to perceive. Accordingly, as perception is the means to acquire knowledge, the means to act virtuously are inherently limited by the body. The heavy dependence on perceptual capacities to live virtuously implies less potential for fulfillment in the physically disabled. Aristotle, however, has no issue

suggesting that those without perceptual capacities are incomplete instantiations of the soul (*DA* II.2.413b33-414a3); no critique in this regard holds weight.

What is problematic, however, is the subsequent implication that the desire for knowledge is inherently limited by right action. Aristotle does not account for the inherent task paralysis faced by an individual deciding between accumulating knowledge and action. If deliberation is the process by which an individual finds the right path, movement along that path – virtuous action – is the goal. Deliberation is desirable only insofar as it leads to action, but time spent deliberating is time that could be spent acting rightly. Aristotle accounts for the physically disabled, but he does not account for this intellectual paralysis.

Aristotle's emphasis on actuality over potentiality implies a preference for action over the accumulation of intellectual capital. Within his framework, there is, properly speaking, no ceiling or floor to "right knowledge"; the human desire for knowledge is inbuilt and unquenchable. Since there is no end to acquiring knowledge, his distinction amounts, in practice, to a distinction between stalling and acting rightly. Accordingly, it remains pertinent to address which animals act without needless deliberation. Incidentally, the intentional separation between rational and more basic creatures implies instead that living beings that act on instinct rather than deliberation are not only more free but superior to those stalled by deliberation. Indeed, the capacity to reason may be an example of human regression in this respect.

Human desire may be graphed in practical syllogisms, but the lack of an end to deliberation or accumulation of knowledge insists that no action can ever be simplified. In fact, his hierarchy of the soul – basic movement, imagination, and wish – is more accurate when inverted. Those operating at a nutritive capacity are guided by mere bodily desire – which, like knowledge, lacks defined barriers. Furthermore, an orientation towards the body rather than 'the

good' is potentially more compelling to advocates of free will. While those who live in accordance with Aristotelian virtue subject themselves to act toward 'the good,' those who choose to only act in line with their body's needs are subject only to themselves. Keeping Aristotle's emphasis on intent and desire in mind, the virtuous ought to learn from the merely nutritive animals.

Aristotle rightly refuses to establish clear ceilings for fundamental capacities in his construction. Happiness, knowledge, and necessary deliberation do not – and cannot – have ends or beginnings. In this respect, a golden mean is impossible to rationalize within a mind paralyzed by a quest for knowledge. An alternative approach could allow for multiple equally moral actions within a given moment; Aristotle, however, distinctly rejects this approach of multiple equally moral actions. Under his framework, one is then either paralyzed by the quest to exercise their potential, or act in accordance with instinct. If habituated virtuous action is what Aristotle calls for, he need not look any further than the plants and less rational animals he rejects.